The 1099 CRNA Handbook

LLC • Taxes • Malpractice • Retirement • Real Talk

Published by LocumsLab

Written by a CRNA with firsthand locums experience.
Based on IRS guidance, AANA data, and real-world experience.

Business Structure | SE Taxes | Malpractice | Solo 401(k) | Finding CPAs

2025 Edition | Data current as of early 2026

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CHAPTER 01

Why This Guide Exists

I'm a CRNA who has been through the locums transition. Like most of you, I didn't learn business in school. Nobody handed me a guide that explained LLCs, quarterly taxes, malpractice tail coverage, or Solo 401(k)s in plain English. I had to piece it together from scattered forum posts, expensive CPA consultations, and advice from veteran CRNAs who'd already figured it out.

This guide is the resource I wish I'd had. It's written from one CRNA to another — not from a CPA or someone who has never held an endotracheal tube. I've tried to make it honest, numbers-focused, and short enough that you'll actually finish it.

What this guide is: A practical financial and operational overview for CRNAs considering or beginning the transition to 1099/locums work.

What this guide is not: Tax advice, legal advice, or a substitute for working with a qualified CPA who understands 1099 healthcare. Please consult a professional before making any financial or legal decisions.

■ The best advice I've received

Make friends with the nurses at every assignment. Save every recruiter and CRNA contact you meet. CRNAs talk to CRNAs — the best contracts come through word of mouth, not job boards.

Always be the CRNA who shows up ready, has a good attitude, and doesn't complain. That reputation gets you invited back and referred to others. "Show up and show out."

CHAPTER 02

Before You Leap — Honest Considerations

Going locums is genuinely exciting — better pay, schedule control, and the ability to supercharge your retirement. But it is not for everyone. Here's what to honestly consider before making the jump.

The lifestyle realities

- You will spend time away from home — hotels, Airbnbs, and hospital call rooms become your second home.
- You will miss events and family time. Decide in advance how much time away is acceptable.
- Every new assignment is a new team. You adapt to the culture — you don't change it.
- Job security feels less stable, even when the market is strong. Keep 6 months of expenses in a liquid cash reserve.
- You are responsible for credentialing, multi-state licensing, and administrative work that your employer used to handle.

The financial realities

- Your W-2 benefits disappear. You now pay 100% of health insurance, malpractice, and retirement contributions.
- You pay self-employment (SE) tax — 15.3% on net income — on top of income tax, until you structure an S-Corp.
- There is no employer withholding. You make quarterly estimated tax payments yourself.
- The higher hourly rate is real, but the true hourly after costs is lower than the headline number.

> ■■ **The benefits gap is bigger than most people expect**
>
> Before going locums, tally everything your W-2 employer provides: health insurance, dental, vision, disability, life insurance, malpractice, retirement match, CME allowance, and licensing fees. For most CRNAs, this totals $25,000–$45,000/year.
>
> You need to earn enough locums income to replace all of this before you're truly ahead. Use the LocumsLab Staff vs Locums calculator at locumslab.com to run your exact numbers.

The upside — why people do it anyway

- **Pay premium:** Locums CRNAs typically earn 30–60% more per hour than W-2 equivalents.
- **Schedule autonomy:** You choose when and where you work.

- **Retirement acceleration:** Up to $70,000/year into a Solo 401(k) vs ~$23,500 as a W-2 employee.
- **Tax deductions:** Travel, malpractice, home office, continuing education, and more become deductible business expenses.
- **Geographic variety:** Work in different states, build experience, expand your clinical skill set.

CHAPTER 03

Business Structure — LLC & S-Corp

This is the chapter most new locums CRNAs underestimate. Your business structure directly determines how much self-employment tax you pay, how you protect personal assets, and what deductions are available. There is no one-size-fits-all answer, but here's the framework.

Step 1: Form an LLC

An LLC (Limited Liability Company) separates your personal assets from your business liabilities. If a claim arises and you are sued, your personal home, savings, and car are protected. Form the LLC before you take your first 1099 check.

Item	Details
Cost to form	$50–$500 depending on state
Annual fees	$0–$800/year (varies by state)
Formation time	1–5 business days online
Where to file	Your state's Secretary of State website
EIN (Tax ID)	Apply free at IRS.gov — takes 5 minutes online
Business bank account	Required — keep personal and business funds separate

■ **Keep your LLCs separate**

If you have an existing LLC for other work (teaching, a side business, a tech product), do not use it for your CRNA clinical work. Mixing clinical income with an unrelated business creates liability exposure and tax complications.

Form a dedicated LLC for your CRNA practice — something like "Your Name CRNA LLC."

Step 2: Default tax treatment as a single-member LLC

By default, a single-member LLC is a "disregarded entity." All income flows to your personal return via Schedule C, and you pay the full 15.3% self-employment tax on net earnings. For most CRNAs earning $150,000+ as 1099, this is where significant money is left on the table compared to electing S-Corp status.

Step 3: Consider electing S-Corp status

An S-Corp election allows you to split income into a reasonable W-2 salary (subject to payroll taxes) and owner distributions (not subject to SE tax). The tax savings on distributions can be substantial.

Scenario	Amount
Gross 1099 income	$300,000
Reasonable W-2 salary (example)	$160,000
Distributions (not subject to SE tax)	$140,000
SE tax without S-Corp	~$41,300
SE tax with S-Corp (on salary only)	~$24,500
Estimated annual savings	**~$16,800/year**

Source: IRS.gov SE tax calculation methodology; example figures for illustration only.

■■ The "reasonable salary" requirement

The IRS requires S-Corp owner-employees to pay themselves a salary comparable to what you'd pay someone else to do the same clinical work. For CRNAs, this means your W-2 salary should reflect market rates for your specialty and region.

Setting salary artificially low (e.g., $40,000 when doing $300,000 of clinical work) is an IRS audit trigger. A CRNA-specialized CPA can document the right number using BLS wage data for your specific role.

Source: CBFC (1099CRNATaxPlanning.com); WCG CPAs & Advisors (wcginc.com)

The administrative fee concept

Some CRNAs use an administrative fee structure within their S-Corp to separately compensate themselves for business management activities — contract negotiation, credentialing, scheduling, and bookkeeping. When properly documented, the S-Corp can pay an administrative fee for these non-clinical services, distinct from the clinical salary. Always structure this with CPA guidance.

When does an S-Corp make financial sense?

The S-Corp comes with overhead: payroll filings, a separate Form 1120-S corporate tax return, and payroll software costs (~$600–$2,000/year). Most CPAs recommend the threshold is around **$80,000–$100,000 in net 1099 income** before tax savings exceed the administrative costs.

■ **S-Corp setup checklist**

Form LLC in your state (Secretary of State website)

Obtain EIN from IRS.gov (free, takes 5 minutes)

Open dedicated business bank account

Set up payroll software (Gusto is most popular for 1099 CRNAs)

File IRS Form 2553 to elect S-Corp status (within 75 days of formation OR by March 15 for current tax year)

Determine reasonable salary with CPA guidance

File quarterly payroll taxes (Form 941)

File annual corporate return (Form 1120-S)

CHAPTER 04

Taxes — What Changes on Day One

The tax picture as a 1099 CRNA is meaningfully different from W-2 employment. Understanding these differences early prevents a painful surprise in April.

Self-Employment (SE) Tax

As a W-2 employee, your employer paid half your Social Security and Medicare taxes (7.65%) and you paid the other half through withholding. As a 1099 contractor, you pay both halves — the full 15.3%.

SE Tax Component	2025 Rate / Rule
Social Security portion	12.4% on first $176,100 of net income (2025)
Medicare portion	2.9% on all net income
Additional Medicare surtax	+0.9% on income over $200,000 (single filer)
Net earnings subject to SE tax	92.35% of net self-employment income
SE tax deduction	50% of SE tax deductible on Form 1040 (above-the-line)

Source: IRS.gov — Self-Employment Tax (Social Security and Medicare Taxes); IRS Topic No. 554

What to set aside

A common rule of thumb: set aside **25–30% of gross income** for taxes. For high-earning CRNAs (over $200,000), 30–35% is safer. This covers SE tax, federal income tax, and leaves a small buffer.

■ Real numbers — CRNA earning $280,000 gross as 1099

SE tax (15.3% x 92.35% x $280,000): ~$39,530

50% SE tax deduction reduces taxable income by ~$19,765

Federal income tax estimate (after standard deduction): ~$58,000–$65,000

Total estimated tax bill: ~$97,000–$104,000

Recommended quarterly set-aside: ~$25,000 per quarter

This drops significantly with S-Corp structuring and retirement contributions.

Quarterly estimated tax payments

Unlike W-2 employment, no one withholds taxes from your 1099 checks. You make quarterly estimated payments directly to the IRS. Underpayment results in penalties.

Quarter	Payment Due Date
Q1 (Jan 1 – Mar 31)	Due April 15
Q2 (Apr 1 – May 31)	Due June 16
Q3 (Jun 1 – Aug 31)	Due September 15
Q4 (Sep 1 – Dec 31)	Due January 15 of following year

Source: IRS.gov — Estimated Taxes

Key deductions available to 1099 CRNAs

- **Malpractice insurance premiums** — fully deductible as a business expense
- **Health insurance premiums** — deductible as an above-the-line adjustment on Form 1040
- **Retirement contributions** — Solo 401(k) or SEP-IRA contributions reduce taxable income dollar-for-dollar
- **Travel to temporary work locations** — flights, lodging, car rental, 50% of meals
- **Licensing and credentialing fees** — state licenses, DEA registration, hospital credentialing costs
- **Continuing education and professional dues** — AANA membership, conferences, CME courses
- **Home office** — if you have a dedicated workspace used exclusively for business
- **Cell phone** — business-use percentage of your phone and service plan
- **Professional equipment** — stethoscopes, medical reference apps, clinical tools

Source: IRS Publication 535 (Business Expenses); AAG Health — How to Work as a CRNA 1099 Independent Contractor

CHAPTER 05

Malpractice Insurance

Malpractice insurance is non-negotiable as a 1099 CRNA. Even if your agency provides coverage for an assignment, that coverage only applies to that assignment with that agency. It does not cover work done for other agencies, direct contracts, or claims filed after the assignment ends.

Claims-Made vs. Occurrence policies

Policy Type	How It Works
Occurrence	Covers any incident that occurred during the policy period, even if the claim is filed years later. No tail needed. More expensive upfront.
Claims-Made	Only covers claims filed while the policy is active. Cheaper upfront but requires tail coverage when you switch or retire.
Tail Coverage	Extends a claims-made policy to cover future claims for past incidents. Typically costs 1.5–2x your annual premium.

What does CRNA malpractice cost?

Item	Data
Average CRNA malpractice premium (2024)	$5,968/year (CMS data)
Typical range for independent CRNAs	$3,000–$7,000+/year
Locums/multi-site premium increase	10–25% higher than single-site
Recommended coverage limits	$1M per claim / $3M–$6M aggregate
Average malpractice claim resolution cost	~$350,000 + ~$43,000 legal fees

Source: VMG Health — CRNA Compensation Trends (citing CMS 2024 data); AAG Health — CRNA 1099 Guide; USALIFETIPS.com — CRNA Malpractice Guide

■■ **Check tail coverage before leaving your W-2 job**

A malpractice claim can take 18–24 months from incident to lawsuit. If your current employer carries a claims-made policy and you leave without tail coverage, you could be personally exposed for incidents that occurred during your employment.

Ask HR whether the employer's policy includes tail coverage. If not, negotiate it as part of your exit package — or budget to purchase it yourself.

Source: The Doctors Company — CRNA Malpractice Insurance

Where to get CRNA malpractice insurance

- **AANA Insurance Services** — purpose-built for CRNAs, 30+ years of specialty experience (malpracticeinsurance.aana.com)
- **The Doctors Company** — large member-owned carrier, covering CRNAs since 1976 (thedoctors.com)
- **NSO (Nurses Service Organization)** — popular, competitive rates for CRNAs
- **Through your agency** — many agencies (CompHealth, AMN, etc.) include malpractice; confirm limits in writing

■ **Questions to ask before any assignment**

Does the agency provide malpractice coverage for this assignment?

Is the policy claims-made or occurrence-based?

What are the per-occurrence and aggregate coverage limits?

Does coverage extend to licensing board investigations?

Who pays for tail coverage when the assignment ends?

CHAPTER 06

Health, Disability & the Benefits Gap

One of the most underestimated costs of going 1099 is replacing the benefits your employer provided. Most CRNAs receive $25,000–$45,000 in total benefits value from their W-2 employer annually. Here's how to account for each piece.

Health Insurance

Coverage Type	Estimated Annual Cost
Individual coverage	$400–$800/month ($4,800–$9,600/year)
Self + spouse	$800–$1,400/month ($9,600–$16,800/year)
Family coverage	$1,200–$2,200/month ($14,400–$26,400/year)
Tax treatment	100% deductible if not eligible for a spouse's employer plan

Disability Insurance

Your most valuable asset as a CRNA is your ability to work. Own-occupation disability insurance pays benefits if you cannot perform your specific job as a CRNA — even if you could work in another field. This distinction is critical.

Item	Details
Typical annual premium for CRNAs	$3,000–$6,000/year
Recommended coverage	60–70% of gross income
Policy type	Own-occupation (not any-occupation)
Elimination period	90 days is most common
Tax treatment	Premiums not deductible; benefits paid tax-free

Other benefits to budget for

Benefit	Estimated Annual Cost
Dental + vision insurance	$500–$1,200/year combined
Life insurance	$600–$2,400/year depending on coverage

CME / continuing education	$1,000–$3,000/year
Multi-state licensing fees	$200–$500/year per additional state
Professional dues (AANA, etc.)	$300–$600/year

■ **Calculate your personal benefits gap**

Add up everything your employer currently provides and compare it to what you'll pay yourself. Most CRNAs are surprised — the gap is often $30,000–$45,000/year.

Use the LocumsLab Staff vs Locums calculator at locumslab.com to calculate your exact benefits gap and see the true comparison.

CHAPTER 07

Retirement — The Real Reason Many Go Locums

This is the chapter that convinced me. As a 1099 CRNA, you can contribute up to $70,000 per year into a Solo 401(k) — compared to roughly $23,500 as a W-2 employee. That difference, compounded over a decade, is genuinely life-changing. Retirement maximization is one of the single biggest financial advantages of locums work.

Solo 401(k) — The gold standard for 1099 CRNAs

A Solo 401(k) is designed for self-employed individuals with no full-time employees other than a spouse. You wear two hats — employee and employer — and can contribute in both capacities.

Contribution Type	2025 Limit
Employee deferral (2025)	$23,500 (pre-tax or Roth)
Catch-up (age 50–59 and 64+)	+$7,500 = $31,000 total employee
Catch-up (age 60–63)	+$11,250 = $34,750 total employee
Employer profit-sharing	Up to 25% of W-2 salary (S-Corp) or ~20% of net SE income
Total cap, under 50 (2025)	$70,000
Total cap, age 50+ (2025)	Up to $81,250
Compensation limit	$350,000 maximum compensation counted

Source: Fidelity.com — Solo 401(k) Contribution Limits 2025; IRS.gov — One-Participant 401k Plans; Blue J Tax Research — 2025 Solo 401(k) Limits

■ What $70,000/year actually becomes

At 7% average annual return:

$70,000/year x 10 years = ~$965,000

$70,000/year x 20 years = ~$2,870,000

Compare to the W-2 maximum of $23,500/year x 20 years = ~$962,000

The 20-year difference: approximately $1.9 million.

This is compounding math, not marketing. But it requires consistently maxing contributions.

SEP-IRA — Simpler but less flexible

A SEP-IRA is easier to set up (no annual filing requirements) and allows contributions up to 25% of compensation, capped at $70,000 in 2025. The downside: no employee deferrals — all contributions are employer-only — so you need higher income to reach the same limit.

SEP-IRA Feature	Details
Max contribution (2025)	$70,000 (25% of compensation, lesser of the two)
Income needed to max out	$280,000+ in net earnings
Roth option	Limited support across providers
Annual filing requirements	None (simpler than Solo 401k)
Best for	Higher earners who prefer simplicity over flexibility

Source: Fidelity.com — SEP-IRA Contribution Limits 2025; IRS.gov — Retirement Plans for Self-Employed

Which is right for you?

Your Situation	Recommended Plan
Lower income (under $150k net)	Solo 401(k) — employee deferrals get you to higher contributions faster
Higher income (over $280k net)	Either works; SEP-IRA is simpler
Want Roth contributions	Solo 401(k) — Roth deferrals available
Minimal paperwork	SEP-IRA — no Form 5500 filing required
Spouse works in your business	Solo 401(k) — can potentially double contributions
S-Corp structure	Solo 401(k) — employer contributions based on W-2 salary

■■ Open your Solo 401(k) before December 31

You must establish your Solo 401(k) plan by December 31 of the tax year to make employee deferrals for that year. Employer profit-sharing contributions can be made until your tax filing deadline (including extensions), but the plan must exist before year-end.

Don't wait until tax season to set this up.

CHAPTER 08

Finding Contracts & Working with Recruiters

Locums contracts come through two channels: staffing agencies and direct contracts with facilities. Most CRNAs start with agencies while building their network, then add direct contracts over time.

Working with agencies

Agencies handle the heavy lifting — credentialing, travel arrangements, housing stipends, and often malpractice coverage. In exchange, they take a margin on your rate, typically 20–40% on top of your pay.

- Work with **multiple agencies** simultaneously to access more opportunities and create rate competition.
- Your **rate is negotiable** — especially once you have completed assignments on your record.
- **Know market rates** before negotiating. Use LocumsLab benchmarks to understand what CRNAs in your specialty and region are earning.
- Understand **guaranteed hours** vs. "expected" hours — guaranteed means you're paid regardless of census.
- Get everything in writing: pay rate, stipends, guaranteed hours, housing, and cancellation terms.

> ■ **The soft skills that actually get you the best assignments**
>
> Make friends with the nurses. They know where everything is, they set the tone of the assignment, and they talk to each other across hospitals. A CRNA who treats nurses as partners gets better schedules, better referrals, and repeat invitations.
>
> Save every contact. The CRNA you work alongside in Phoenix might know about an excellent contract in Charlotte next year. Your network is your pipeline.
>
> "Show up and show out." Be early, be prepared, be positive. The locums world is smaller than you think — your reputation travels faster than your resume.

Evaluating a contract offer

- **Hourly vs. weekly rate** — know which you're being quoted and convert appropriately.
- **Housing stipend** — is it tax-free reimbursement or taxable income? Matters significantly for take-home.
- **Guaranteed hours** — are hours guaranteed or contingent on hospital census?

- **Case mix and call** — what types of cases? Is call required, and what is the on-call pay rate?
- **Supervision model** — what is the CRNA-to-anesthesiologist ratio and level of supervision required?
- **State license requirement** — do you need a license in that state, and who pays for it?

■ **Use LocumsLab to evaluate any offer**

The True Hourly Rate calculator at locumslab.com takes a contract offer and shows you the real effective hourly rate after SE taxes, malpractice, health insurance, and travel costs. Use it before signing anything.

CHAPTER 09

Payroll, Quarterly Taxes & Bookkeeping

Once you have an S-Corp, you need payroll. This is administrative overhead most people don't anticipate. Here's how to set it up and keep it running without consuming your weekends.

Payroll software

Software	Notes
Gusto	Most popular for 1099 CRNA S-Corps. Handles W-2, payroll tax deposits, and quarterly filings automatically. ~$50/month + $6/person.
QuickBooks Payroll	Good integration with QuickBooks accounting. ~$50–$85/month.
Run by ADP	More robust for compliance. Higher cost. Better if you eventually hire employees.

Bookkeeping & expense tracking

Software	Notes
QuickBooks Self-Employed	Good for sole proprietors. Tracks mileage, estimates quarterly taxes. ~$20/month.
QuickBooks Online	Better for S-Corps with more transactions. ~$35–$60/month.
Keeper	AI-powered expense tracking, finds deductions automatically, CPA access built in. ~$20/month.
Wave	Free, basic bookkeeping. Good starting point.

The quarterly compliance routine

Timing	Action
Every paycheck	Run payroll through Gusto; federal and state tax deposits are made automatically
Monthly	Reconcile business bank account; categorize and log expenses

Quarterly	File Form 941 (payroll taxes); make estimated income tax payment; review S-Corp distributions
Annually	File Form 1120-S (S-Corp return); issue W-2 to yourself; make final retirement contribution

■ **The tax savings account rule — start from Day 1**

Open a dedicated savings account labeled "taxes." Every time a 1099 check hits your business account, immediately transfer 30% to the tax account. Treat it as untouchable.

This money belongs to the IRS and your quarterly payment schedule. The CRNAs who get into trouble in April are the ones who spent their tax reserve. Don't be that person.

CHAPTER 10

Finding the Right CPA

This is the most common pain point I hear from CRNAs considering the transition. Finding a CPA who genuinely understands 1099 healthcare — CRNA income, S-Corp elections, reasonable salary determinations for clinical professionals, and the nuances of locums deductions — is genuinely hard. Most general CPAs have never worked with a CRNA.

What to look for

- **Healthcare 1099 experience** — ask how many 1099 CRNAs, physicians, or allied health professionals they currently serve.
- **S-Corp expertise** — they should be fluent in reasonable compensation, Form 1120-S, and payroll tax strategy.
- **Proactive planning** — a good CPA calls you in Q3 to review and plan, not just in March to file.
- **Locums deduction knowledge** — travel, malpractice, multi-state licensing, home office, administrative fees.
- **Clear fee structure** — know upfront what you're paying. Typical fees for S-Corp CRNAs: $2,000–$5,000/year.

Questions to ask when interviewing a CPA

- "How many 1099 CRNA clients do you currently work with?"
- "How do you determine reasonable S-Corp salary for a CRNA?"
- "Do you prepare Form 1120-S in-house or refer it out?"
- "How do you handle income earned across multiple states?"
- "What do you charge for quarterly planning vs. annual filing only?"

■ Firms that specialize in CRNA and healthcare 1099

A few firms specifically serve the CRNA and healthcare 1099 market:

CBFC (1099CRNATaxPlanning.com) — dedicated 1099 CRNA tax planning

WCG CPAs & Advisors (wcginc.com) — 160+ CRNA clients, strong S-Corp expertise

CRNA Financial Planning (crnafinancialplanning.com) — financial planning focused

A strong generalist CPA with S-Corp experience and willingness to learn your specialty can also work well. The key is finding someone proactive — not someone who just files what you hand them.

■ **CPA fees are worth it — and deductible**

A CRNA-specialized CPA typically costs $2,000–$5,000/year. If they save you $15,000–$25,000 in taxes through proper S-Corp structuring and deduction optimization, the ROI is obvious.

Their fee is fully deductible as a business expense.

CHAPTER 11

Run Your Numbers — LocumsLab

Reading a guide is a start. The real insight comes from running your specific numbers — your current salary, your benefits costs, your target contract rate. That's exactly what LocumsLab was built to do.

Free calculators at locumslab.com

Calculator	What It Does
Quick Start Wizard	Step-by-step W-2 to locums comparison. Best starting point for newcomers.
Staff vs Locums	Side-by-side financial comparison of your current W-2 vs a specific locums contract.
True Hourly Rate	Enter any contract offer. See the real hourly after SE taxes, insurance, malpractice, and travel.
W-2 vs 1099	Model the tax and income differences between employment types.
Tax Estimator	Estimate quarterly payments and annual tax liability.
10-Year Income Model	Project long-term income under different scenarios.
Home Buying Calculator	Understand how 1099 income affects mortgage qualification.

Pro Feature	What It Does
S-Corp Evaluator (Pro)	Model S-Corp tax savings vs sole proprietor LLC for your income level.
Market Benchmarks (Pro)	Current CRNA locums rate data by specialty, region, and role.

■ Start here: the Quick Start Wizard

Go to locumslab.com and click Quick Start. It walks you through entering your current W-2 details and a target locums rate, then shows a side-by-side financial comparison in under 5 minutes.

No signup required to run the calculators. Sign up free to save and share your scenarios.

Have a contract offer? Run it through the True Hourly Rate calculator first. Most CRNAs are surprised by how the true number differs from the headline rate.

Thank you for reading. If this guide was useful, share it with a colleague who is considering the transition.

locumslab.com

DISCLAIMER

This guide is provided for informational and educational purposes only. It does not constitute tax advice, legal advice, financial advice, or professional advice of any kind. The information reflects the author's general understanding of tax law and financial planning concepts as of early 2026 and may not apply to your specific situation.

Tax laws change. IRS guidance evolves. State laws vary significantly. All figures, rates, and limits cited are based on 2025 IRS guidance and should be independently verified before making any financial or tax decision.

Always consult a qualified CPA, tax attorney, and/or licensed financial advisor before making decisions about business structure, tax strategy, retirement planning, or insurance coverage.

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